PART IV · HARMONY · 12

Progressions everywhere

A **progression** is a trip from chord to chord. A handful of trips turn up in song after song. Learn them by their numbers and you can play them in any key.

THE SECRET
Most songs take the same few trips: home, away, a pull, and home again.

I home · vi iii home's cousins · IV ii away · V the pull back home

The pop four
countless pop songs and ballads

I C → V G → vi Am → IV F

The fifties
old rock 'n' roll and doo-wop

I C → vi Am → IV F → V G

The jazz three-step
jazz standards (as ii7, V7, Imaj7)

ii Dm → V G → I C

The canon
Pachelbel's Canon and its many children

I C → V G → vi Am → iii Em → IV F → I C → IV F → V G

1. Learn the trip by **numbers**: I V vi IV.
2. Pick a key and turn the numbers into chords: in C, **C G Am F**.
3. Play it round and round. Change key: the numbers stay the same.

Same trip, any key

The pop four	I	V	vi	IV
in C	C	G	Am	F
in G	G	D	Em	C
in F	F	C	Dm	B♭
in D	D	A	Bm	G

EXAMPLE

Play the pop four in G major

I G → V D → vi Em → IV C

1. **I** is the key note: G.
2. **V** is the 5th note of the G scale: D. **vi** is the 6th: E, minor, so Em.
3. **IV** is the 4th note: C.

G, D, Em, C: **the pop four in G**. Same trip, new key.

PART IV · HARMONY · 12 · CONTINUED

GAME

Name the trip

1 C · Am · F · G

2 Dm · G · C

3 C · G · Am · F

All in C major. Turn each into numbers, then name the trip: the pop four, the fifties or the jazz three-step.

Answer: 1 the fifties (I vi IV V) · 2 the jazz three-step (ii V I) · 3 the pop four (I V vi IV).

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS
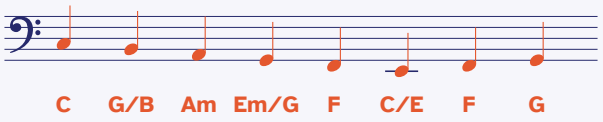


Play C, G, Am, F, four beats each.

Go round four times without stopping, left hand plays the chord's name note (C for C, A for Am), right hand the whole snowman. Hum any tune you like over it.

YOU KNOW THIS

Pachelbel's Canon: the trip under the tune



In the version everyone plays, the bass walks down (inversions smooth it), and above it the chords take the **canon trip**: C G Am Em F C F G. Countless songs borrow it.

Try it. Play the bass slowly with your left hand and the chords in your right.

THINK OF IT A walk round the block: leave home, wander, feel the pull, and turn the corner back home.

TRAP

- × Learning songs one by one: learn the trip by numbers, then change key.
- × Mixing up the pop four and the fifties: same four chords, different order. Listen to which chord comes second.

SEE ALSO

Chords in a key p. 92 · Cadences p. 113 · Chords under a melody p. 115

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Harmony 12 · Online: Library › Chords